唐詩

TANG POEMS

Li Bai · Du Fu · Wang Wei

with the English verse of Herbert A. Giles

明
月

Night Thoughts

LI BAI · 701–762

I wake, and moonbeams play around my bed,
    Glittering like hoar-frost to my wondering eyes;
Up towards the glorious moon I raise my head,
    Then lay me down,—and thoughts of home arise.

靜夜思

〔唐〕李白

牀前明月光，疑是地上霜。①

舉頭望明月，低頭思故鄉。②

① **牀** chuáng, now written 床: a bed. Some commentators read it as the railing round a well, others as a folding seat set out in the courtyard; Giles keeps the bed.

② **明月** míngyuè, the bright moon. The collected works of Li Bai read 山月 here, the moon over the hills, and 看月光 in the first line; the 1705 edition of all Tang poetry reads 山月 but keeps 明月光. This page follows the anthology of 1763, the text Chinese children learn by heart. **鄉** xiāng rhymes with 光 guāng and 霜 shuāng at the ends of the first two lines; Giles rhymes his quatrain on alternate lines instead.

Drinking Alone under the Moon

LI BAI · 701–762

An arbour of flowers and a kettle of wine:
Alas! in the bowers no companion is mine.
Then the moon sheds her rays on my goblet and me,
And my shadow betrays we're a party of three.

Though the moon cannot swallow her share of the grog,
And my shadow must follow wherever I jog,—
Yet their friendship I'll borrow and gaily carouse,
And laugh away sorrow while spring-time allows.

See the moon,—how she glances response to my song;
See my shadow,—it dances so lightly along!
While sober I feel you are both my good friends;
When drunken I reel, our companionship ends.
But we'll soon have a greeting without a good-bye,
At our next merry meeting away in the sky.

月下獨酌

〔唐〕李白

花間一壺酒，獨酌無相親。
舉杯邀明月，對影成三人。①

月既不解飲，影徒隨我身。
暫伴月將影，行樂須及春。②

我歌月徘徊，我舞影零亂。
醒時同交歡，醉後各分散。
永結無情遊，相期邈雲漢。③

① **三人** sān rén, three people: the poet, the moon and his shadow.

② **將** jiāng: here it joins 月 to 影, the moon to the shadow.

③ **無情遊** wúqíng yóu: a friendship with companions who feel nothing, the moon and the shadow; the poet binds himself to it for good. **雲漢** yúnhàn: the Milky Way, where the three will meet again, away in the sky. The rhyme changes at the ninth line, where the third stanza of Giles begins.

Stop-short

DU FU · 712–770

White gleam the gulls across the darkling tide,
    On the green hills the red flowers seem to burn;
Alas! I see another spring has died....
    When will it come—the day of my return?

絕句

〔唐〕杜甫

江碧鳥逾白，山青花欲燃。①

今春看又過，何日是歸年。②

① **逾** yú, all the more: against the green of the river the birds look whiter still. **欲燃** yù rán, about to catch fire: the red of the flowers, which in Giles seem to burn.

② **歸年** guī nián, the year of going home. Du Fu wrote this quatrain, the second of a pair, in the spring of 764 at Chengdu, where the war in the north had driven him.

The Bamboo Lodge

WANG WEI · 701–761

Beneath the bamboo grove, alone,
I seize my lute and sit and croon;
No ear to hear me, save mine own:
No eye to see me—save the moon.

竹里館

〔唐〕王維

獨坐幽篁裏，彈琴復長嘯。①

深林人不知，明月來相照。

① **幽篁** yōuhuáng: a deep, dark grove of bamboo. **長嘯** cháng xiào: a long whistle through pursed lips, the art of recluses; in Giles the poet croons. The Bamboo Lodge was one of twenty places on the estate of Wang Wei at Wangchuan, south-east of the Tang capital, and he gave each of them a quatrain in 輞川集, the Wangchuan collection.

A note on the text

ABOUT THIS EDITION

The Chinese poems follow *Three Hundred Tang Poems*, the anthology Sun Zhu compiled in 1763 under the name Hengtang Tuishi, except Du Fu's quatrain, which is not in it and is printed as the *Complete Tang Poems* of 1705 gives it. All four are taken from Wikisource in traditional characters, with the old forms of some characters as found there.

The English verse is Herbert A. Giles's, as he printed it in *A History of Chinese Literature* (1901), where the poems have no titles; the English titles are this edition's. Giles wrote Li Po and Tu Fu for Li Bai and Du Fu, and called the four-line *jueju* a "stop-short", which gives Du Fu's poem its English name. His rhymes, indents and punctuation are kept; the moonlight poem, which his book printed in half-lines, is set here in whole lines.

Each Chinese poem is set two lines of verse to a row, so that every row faces the two lines of English that render it. The space between the stanzas of the moonlight poem is the editor's, added on both pages.

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